

Proteus anguinus

Olm



Location S. Europe

Length 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding Not known season
Status Vulnerable



The olm is one of the few amphibians that has become adapted to life in caves. It has a long and very slender body, a pinkish skin almost devoid of pigment, rudimentary eyes, and 2 pairs of tiny limbs—the front pair

with 3 toes, and the rear pair with only 2. It also has red feathery external gills, which it retains throughout its life. Olms inhabit streams in caves, sometimes several miles from a cave opening, and feed on small invertebrates.



Chioglossa lusitanica

Golden-striped salamander



Location S.W. Europe

Length 4¼–5½ in (12–14 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Early spring season
Status Vulnerable



The slender body and long tail enable the golden-striped salamander to run very fast, like a lizard. Its coloration is dark brown, with 2 yellow, copper, or golden stripes on its back that merge to form a single stripe on the tail. This salamander



has large eyes and a long, sticky tongue for catching insects. If attacked, it may shed its tail. During the breeding season, swellings appear on the upper front legs of males. After mating, females lay their 15–20 eggs under rocks in well-oxygenated but often slightly acidic streams.

Salamandra salamandra

Fire salamander



Location Europe

Length 7–11 in (18–28 cm)
Habit Wholly terrestrial
Breeding Spring, summer, season after heavy rain
Status Least concern



Similar in appearance to the tiger salamander (see p.444), this robust amphibian has an eye-catching coloration that warns predators that it is poisonous. It produces a toxic secretion from glands behind its eyes, and this is distasteful to anything attempting to eat it. The fire salamander inhabits forests and woodland on hills and mountains; it spends the winter underground. Breeding involves the male grasping his mate from below and depositing a spermatophore; he then flips to one side so that she falls on it. The eggs develop

FEEDING HABITS



The fire salamander is active mainly at night, especially after rain, when it emerges from beneath logs and stones to feed on worms, slugs, insects, and insect larvae.

inside the female until the larval stage, and are then released into ponds or streams. During their development in the oviduct, larvae are occasionally cannibalistic, eating their smaller siblings as eggs or larvae. In some high-altitude populations, the young develop to the adult form inside the mother's body.



BODY COLOR

The body color is variable, depending on geographical location. It can be black and yellow, or yellow with black spots or stripes. In some areas, the yellow may be replaced by orange or red.

Tylototriton verrucosus

Crocodile newt



Location S. and S.E. Asia

Length 5½–7 in (14–18 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Monsoon season
Status Least concern



Also known as the mandarin salamander, this robust newt has a large head and thickset body, with rough black skin. The prominent orange warts, ridges, and glands indicate that the crocodile newt will exude distasteful skin secretions if attacked. This newt lives most of its life on land—spending winter and dry periods underground—but during the monsoon it migrates to breeding ponds, where it attaches its eggs to water plants. Active at night, the crocodile newt feeds on invertebrates.



Triturus cristatus

Great crested newt



Location Europe, C. Asia

Length 4–5½ in (10–14 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Spring and summer
Status Least concern



Also known as the warty newt, this secretive animal lives mostly on land but spends about 3–5 months of the year in ponds, lakes, and ditches. It is dark brown above, with a characteristically warty skin, and bright orange with black spots below. During

the breeding season, the male develops a large, jagged crest on its back, and a white or blue streak along the tail. Like many other newts, the male courts the female with a complex underwater dance, and concludes the display by transferring a spermatophore to the female. The female lays her eggs singly and wraps them in leaves, probably for protection. These newts are widespread throughout Europe, but in many areas their numbers have decreased because their breeding habitat has been drained.



Ichthyosaura alpestris

Alpine newt



Location Europe

Length 2¼–4¼ in (6–12 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Spring season
Status Least concern



The alpine newt has a small body, blue above and bright orange below, and a short tail. In the breeding season, the male develops a low, black and white crest along his back, black and white spots on his sides and tail, and a swollen cloaca. As with most newts, the male attracts the female by fanning his tail and wafting a pheromone toward her snout. In the Balkans, some of these nocturnal animals are permanently aquatic, retaining larval features, such as external gills, into adulthood.

